

SAPRA DAS



Rebellion in the Ranks

DELHI Just when the BJP was trying to showcase its expanding ally-base for the Lok Sabha polls, its own ranks have revolted in Uttarakhand against "the dictatorial attitude" of Chief Minister B.C. Khanduri. Despite the central party leadership trying its best to keep the dissent under wraps, 25 of its 37 MLAs came out in the open, submitting their resignations to BJP President Rajnath Singh. According to party

sources, the MLAs, led by senior state leader and former chief minister B.S. Koshiyari, met Singh on October 19 and handed over their resignations. The party chief urged them not to precipitate matters and asked them to think things over.

Once they returned, however, the chief minister reportedly came down harshly on the MLAs, provoking them to give in their resignations. These included Trivendra Singh

MAJOR MUTINY: Koshiyari (left) and Khanduri

Ravat, a minister in the Khanduri Government. The central leadership now fears that the situation may snowball and more MLAs may join the rank of dissidents.

The situation in the state had been simmering ever the retired major-general took over as chief minister last year. The majority of the MLAs had favoured Koshiyari for the post. L.K. Advani had insisted on Khanduri, impressed with his stint as surface transport minister in the NDA government.

It may prove catastrophic for the BJP to replace Khanduri just before the polls. The party is also taking advantage of the fact that Koshiyari, an RSS man, is averse to joining hands with the Congress to form the next government in the state. The Congress is willing to extend support in a 70-seat state Assembly.

For Khanduri, the infighting within the BJP may just work in his favour.

by Bhavna Vij-Aurora

SIGNPOSTS

DIED: Former Meghalaya chief minister and state Assembly Speaker **E.K. Mawlong**, 64. He was a United Democratic Party MLA from Umroi and chief minister from September 2000 to December 2001.

BROKEN: By **Sachin Tendulkar**, Brian Lara's record of 11,953 Test runs with 12,027, becoming the highest run-getter in Test cricket. He passed the record at Mohali against Australia.



DIED: Tamil film director **Sridhar**, 63. He had introduced actor-turned-politician J. Jayalalithaa to movies.

CONFERRED: On actor **Shabana Azmi**, the second Fakhruddin Ali Ahmed Award for 2007 for national integration, by President Pratibha Patil.

WON: By **Arjun Atwal**, the Nationwide Tour's Chattanooga Classic golf tournament in Tennessee, US.

VIS-A-VIS **BIMAN BOSE** CPI(M) West Bengal secretary **versus** **MAMATA BANERJEE** Trinamool Congress chief

“It is the brand of politics of Mamata Banerjee which is helping the Left Front in West Bengal.”



SAURABH SINGH

“Let the CPI(M) be guided by the Tatas. We will be guided by the people. Let Mr Tata join politics and oppose us politically.”

EPILOGUE: The Nano may have driven off to Gujarat, but it remains a horse to flog in West Bengal.